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# Digital Tools

Technology For Personal and SoHo Productivity

**Saurabh Kumar**

**A**s the world goes belligerent on outsourcing, and big companies in India make money that would make traditional big ticket manufacturing outfits cringe, a diminutive company in New Delhi is quietly creating a small revolution. It is earning projects from across the world—not by sending project and account managers on whirlwind US trips, not by advertising on prominent online sites, and not by having a huge staff on its business development team.

It relies on the old faithful—the World Wide Web—for procuring new projects and earning money. In dollars.

At last count, Synapse Communications, the company in question, had earned nearly \$85,000 through overseas projects using a Web service called elance.com, a Web site that launched in 1999, and is today an acknowledged leader in the Services Procurement and Management market.

Just about the right raw material you need to jumpstart your earnings—as an individual or as a professional outfit. Synapse Communications, for instance, has been a software development company for over eight years, but as Chief Operating Officer Kapil Gupta says, “Elance provided us with a focused platform. We have been growing at a rapid pace, and Elance Online has provided us with good business opportunities.”

**Use your  
skillset to  
work for  
global clients  
sitting at  
home.**

**Jumpstart**

## A Web of Opportunities

**New Delhi-based firm Synapse Communications earned more than Rs 40 lakh by bidding for worldwide projects online. Are you next?**

In English, this means that you, as an individual or a company, can bid for a project in various categories—software, creative writing, photography, 3D graphics, image editing, Web site design, banner ads, logo design, the works. Think of any topic, and Elance Online allows you to place a project or bid for one.

Elance was set up by an IIT Bombay graduate Beerud Sheth in 1999, a year after two Harvard Business School scholars—Thomas W Malone and Robert Laubacher—published an article in the Harvard Business Review titled, “The Dawn of the E-Lance Economy.”

Among other things, the article spoke about how “the devolution of large, permanent corporations into flexible, temporary networks of individuals” was already underway. They also wrote about how the Internet will lower business transaction costs, and how these lower costs will change the “economic equation.” They bravely predicted that this kind of business will define work in the 21st century.

Based on this philosophy, Sheth (also a Massachusetts Institute of Technology postgraduate) and his Elance team created their first product—the Elance Online Service Marketplace—in 1999. Ever since, it has been the link between thousands of business and service providers from



Illustration: Mahesh Benkar